

Signature Assignment for ENC 3027 – Topics in Tech

Comm: Rehumanizing Data

Delivery Context

Prior to this assignment, students will have been exposed to key concepts such as datafication, data humanism, and feminist ethics of care. Specific readings that will help ground their knowledge of these terms will include:

Al-Hazwani, I., Zhang, K. E., Garrison, L., & Bernard, J. (2025). *Data Humanism Decoded: A Characterization of its Principles to Bridge Data Visualization Researchers and Practitioners* (arXiv:2509.00440). arXiv. <https://doi.org/10.48550/arXiv.2509.00440>

Drucker, J. (2020). *Visualization and Interpretation: Humanistic Approaches to Display*. MIT Press.

Drucker, J. (2021). *The Digital Humanities Coursebook: An Introduction to Digital Methods for Research and Scholarship*. Routledge.

Lupi, G. (2017, January 30). Data Humanism: The Revolutionary Future of Data Visualization. *PRINT Magazine*. <https://www.printmag.com/article/data-humanism-future-of-data-visualization/>

Sutherland, T., Cifor, M., Cowan, T. L., Rault, J., & Garcia, P. (2023). The Feminist Data Manifest-NO: An Introduction and Four Reflections. In M. K. Gold & L. F. Klein (Eds.), *Debates in the Digital Humanities 2023*. University of Minnesota Press.

In a previous low-stakes assignment, they already built and evaluated an artifact built by Claude after which they regenerated the artifacts based on their knowledge on data humanism principles. Hence in this major assignment, they will turn to digital humanities projects available online to unpack and interpret how they embody feminist ethics of care and data humanistic principles that center individual voices, care over extraction, and subjectivity amongst others.

Assignment: Rehumanizing Data

Learning objectives:

Upon the completion of this assignment, students will be able to:

- i. Explain data humanism and feminist ethics of care
- ii. Identify and interpret data humanistic principles in digital humanities projects
- iii. Articulate gaps between digital humanities projects and other data-driven projects in public communication
- iv. Express rhetorical choices behind data visualization projects and respectfully evaluate how projects center or erase stories
- v. Articulate the ethical responsibilities of data collectors, curators, and communicators toward the people their data represents
- vi. Adapt the data humanism framework to projects within their fields

These objectives align with the broader goals of the course.

This signature assignment is scaffolded in two stages. In the first stage, students build analytical fluency by identifying and evaluating an existing digital humanities project through the data humanism heuristic they have learnt. In the second stage, they apply that understanding to produce original work. This is a multimodal project that takes a real news article reporting on a public health risk, crisis, or disaster and transforms it into either a policy brief or a community-facing narrative. This assignment takes into consideration students' cognitive, affective, and psychomotor skills to move them from understanding data humanism in theory to practicing it under real conditions.

The core output is a multimodal project which can be approached in two ways:

1. A policy brief where students communicate to decision makers and professionals such as public health officials, NGOs, business analysts, or government agencies about how data should be handled differently.
2. A community-facing narrative that rewrite articles for the community (mis)represented in the data.

Stage 1: Analytical essay (7-10 pages) – Due by Spring break.

This assignment is aimed at assessing their understanding of key concepts as well as the heuristic for incorporating data humanistic principles and feminist principles of care in data work. Consequently, students will be required to identify digital humanities projects and analyze how they exemplify the heuristic of care, embodiment, contextualization, small data, and subjectivity.

Prior to this assignment, they will also be exposed to multiple resources for locating DH projects and there will be an initial class exercise evaluating the following projects:

Klein, L., Sharma, T., Varner, J., Li, S., Adams, M., Yang, N., Jutan, D., Fu, J., Mola, A., Fang, Z., Li, Y., & Munro, S. (2024, May 1). Data By Design. Data by Design. <https://dataxdesign.io/about>

Middle Passage Virtual Reality Experience. (n.d.). Center for Humanities and Digital Research. Retrieved November 11, 2025, from <https://chdr.cah.ucf.edu/mpe/#>

Responsible Datasets in Context. (2024). <https://www.responsible-datasets-in-context.com/>

Stage 2: Multimodal Project (Group work) – Due at the end of the semester

Working in small groups, students select **30-50 news articles** reporting on a public health risk, crisis, or disaster; one that relies heavily on data, statistics, or demographic figures. Then they will move through a **structured sequence of close reading, AI-assisted distant reading, and reflective synthesis** before producing a **multimodal project** of their choosing. The multimodal projects can take the form of a blog, vlog, video, social media post, podcast, etc.; and depending on format, may integrate written argument with visual elements such as annotated excerpts, comparative data displays, or infographics that demonstrate the difference between datafied and humanized communication.

Based on their analysis and findings, students produce one of two project types:

Option A: Policy Brief

This brief makes an evidence-based argument for how data about this crisis should be communicated differently. The brief should identify the specific failures of the original article

across the heuristic dimensions, articulate the human cost of those failures, and recommend concrete, actionable changes grounded in data humanism principles.

Option B: Community-Facing Narrative

Students rewrite the article for the community (mis)represented in the data. The goal is to tell the same story with the same data, but in a way that restores embodiment, care, context, and subjectivity.

Note:

Both options require a process document, a reflective essay of 1-2 pages accounting for how the group moved from close reading through AI interrogation to final product, including what they changed, what they struggled with, and what the process taught them about their own relationship to data.

Assessment

Participation in group activity – 15%

Reflective essay/ process document – 15%

Multimodal project – 40%

Presentation & Peer dialogue – 15%

Guidelines for AI Use

In this assignment, students can use AI to support textual analysis and distant reading of the articles. However, AI is under study since they have to interrogate its output rather than accept it. In addition, the multimodal component as well as the [individual] reflective essay will make visible AI's role as well as student's voice and thoughts.